

The Fable of Deirdre & Bryn

In A FAR-OFF LAND stood a mighty mountain, its dark tree-green slopes topped by a grey stony summit. At its foot sat the small whitewashed cottage where Deirdre and Bryn lived. They were very much in love, in the unquestioning, wholehearted and wonderful way that young people have. They lived simply, growing their own food, and their intimate world did not include the kind of distracting ephemera which afflict us here.

Their idyllic days were tarnished with a tinge of sadness, for their union had, as yet, no issue.

They were very different to look at. Deirdre was tall, slim, pale, with long brown hair which from time to time she dyed a light and delicate green. Bryn was considerably shorter, strongly built, with the kind of efficient countryman's brawn which makes light of forest work. While both loved the open air, they differed in their tastes. Deirdre preferred to roam through the forest, enjoying the cool and peace of the trees and the water running down the burns; Bryn enjoyed the upper slopes, where huge rocks were a challenge on the way to the ice-scoured mountaintop. The treeline, where occasional birches and alders invaded the moorland below the boulder-field, was where they both felt happiest. Full of exuberance, they would play hide and seek. Bryn would hunker down, so that in his hodden grey he looked somewhat like a large stone, almost indistinguishable from the boulders embedded in the moss. Deirdre, when it was her turn, found a spot in a small grove of silver birches, where she stood, arms held in such a way that she seemed almost to be a tree.

Their love sustained them through the winter's storms, but spring arrived and there was no sign of the infant they both desired. Their childlessness grew to an ache which drove them to seek counsel in the nearby village. The wise woman Deirdre consulted could find no reason for her barrenness, and the learned doctor Bryn spoke with was sure that in time they would conceive.

But the years went by without the desired outcome, and Deirdre grew ever more sorrowful. She took to standing alone on the mountainside for hours on end, looking at the clouds. Bryn, sad but stoical, put all his energy into working the land. One evening, though dusk had fallen, Deirdre had not returned, so Bryn climbed up through the forest to the treeline, where he found her gazing at the stars and singing softly the saddest of songs. She smiled at him but did not move, so he sat down at her feet and covered his head against the cool wind. There they remained, deep in their shared melancholy, and as clouds rolled in to cover the moon, they merged with the darkness and the mountain.

The villagers found the cottage empty and weeds growing among the cabbages, so they went searching through the woods for Deirdre and Bryn, without success. But at the edge of the moorland, high above, there was a solitary weeping silver birch tree, with a rough boulder at its foot.

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I climbed that mountain in spring a couple of years ago, and near the treeline I found a weeping birch. It had grown over and through a large stone, its roots penetrating deep inside the rocky crevices to find nourishment. A slight gust of wind made the light green leaves rustle softly, and it seemed to me like a sigh of contentment, for all around the tree birch saplings were growing.